FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

NEWSMAKER OF THE YEAR

As a year, 2022 has been difficult to define. The world had believed it was out of the Covid-19 nightmare, and that life was beginning to get back to a new spring. But February itself got us the Ukraine war, plunging things into a new uncertainty. And as the year winds down, even as the war rages, the pandemic stalks us again. What made the year special though is the human spirit, working its path across domains—in business, sport, politics, cinema.

We feature in this issue the most engaging parts of what we witnessed this year. Gautam Adani, chairman of the Ahmedabad-based Adani Group, became the richest person in India and Asia and the third richest in the world. The self-made entrepreneur did so with his explosive growth strategy in 2022 that propelled his group to the pinnacle of Indian business. His group's market capitalisation grew nine-fold in just three years to cross Rs 17.9 lakh crore, making it India's second most valuable business house, just behind the Tatas but ahead of Reliance. The $10.5 billion (around Rs 87,000 crore) buyout of Swiss firm Holcim's stake in ACC and Ambuja Cements has become his latest—and perhaps boldest—move, making it India's single largest deal in infrastructure. In doing so, the Adani Group became the second-largest cement producer in the country. Adani is already India's largest private sector power producer, port operator, airport operator, consumer gas and electric transmission company, apart from being the largest infrastructure developer and generator of renewable energy. This year saw his ever-expanding empire encompass the country's largest marine services company, a media network, telecom and foodgrains. And all this while his group committed Rs 60,000 crore to charity on his 60th birthday this June—money that will go into health and education, the two things that will create a foundation for future growth for everyone.



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It was because of his explosive growth both in business and personal wealth, in the face of extreme adversity, that INDIA TODAY has made Gautam Adani our Newsmaker of the Year 2022. Gautam wears his richness lightly and with a becoming modesty, as Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa and Executive Editor M.G. Arun found when they met him at the Adani headquarters in Ahmedabad. What was to be a half-hour chat went on for nearly 90 minutes as the elusive billionaire opened up on how he grew his business, his management style and his life's philosophy. Gautam then agreed to go on record with a print and video interview with Chengappa and did not shy away from answering his critics, who see his phenomenal rise as linked to that of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and the charge that his companies were heavily overleveraged. "Rankings and numbers do not matter to me," he told INDIA TODAY. "I get my thrills from handling challenges—the bigger they are, the happier I am." That is an ambition, in small or big ways, that we can all aspire to in the coming year.

There were others who were a powerful influence in the events that shaped 2022. Prime Minister Modi not only exhibited his enduring hold on the Indian political mind with perhaps the most stunning electoral victories in his career—in March, Uttar Pradesh, and as the year wound down, in Gujarat. Despite the world economy being in recession, India remained the fastest-growing large economy in the world. There were challenges, with rising inflation and shortage of jobs, but he persevered on the path of reforms. PM Modi has aggressively pushed the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) in various sectors to boost exports and improve the share of manufacturing in the nation's GDP. His commitment to investing massively in the nation's infrastructure remained steadfast, committing about Rs 100 lakh crore till just 2025. He continued his penchant for bold initiatives with the introduction of the Agniveer scheme for the armed forces in an effort to reform them, by cutting flab and injecting younger blood. It was a brave idea whose time had come because a huge chunk of the defence budget—53 per cent—was going towards paying salaries and pensions, with capital expenditure for new equipment and infrastructure shrinking to 27.4 per cent. The year saw India reaping early yield trade pacts with Australia and the UAE. The country also leaped to 5G telecom technology, and added modern semi-high-speed trains. Always keeping the needy in mind, PM Modi also announced the continuation of the scheme for free 5 kg of foodgrains per person for 800 million for another year. He remains the defining force on India's political landscape and internationally his voice is taken seriously. From December, G20 got into Indian leadership for a year, allowing PM Modi to showcase his idea of globalisation, especially when the world order is altering. He also crafted another decisive move, one that has the capacity to alter the polity. The Adivasi has hitherto been the furthermost from the mainstream. But 2022 gave us Droupadi Murmu. The new President of India, through the passage of her own life, defines what the country really is.

Rahul Gandhi has been often called an absentee politician, not capable of matching up to his own illustrious forebears. But he has put his own mind and body to the most exacting engagement with the soil. The politics he serves are not in the most robust state, though. The grand drama through which Eknath Shinde departed from the MVA alliance in Maharashtra proved that. But alliances being made up of the unlikeliest of partners only shows how Indian politics is evolving beyond the terms set decades ago. The coming together of the Bihar politicians, Nitish Kumar and Tejashwi Yadav, is a measure of that. So is the coming to maturity of the Aam Aadmi Party as it got certified as a national party. Bhagwant Mann, who started as a comedian, became the AAP's chief minister for Punjab, making history of sorts. Rishi Sunak, as the first Asian-origin prime minister of the UK, too has it, in a development that would have been unthinkable even two decades ago.

The year was also made up of a rather diverse cast of characters. If Sukash Chandrashekar shocked us with what smart chicanery can do, cricketer Suryakumar Yadav was the new hero for our cricket-crazed country. South Indian cinema was seen as provincial, as something that belongs only to people who speak languages that others do not understand. It bested the mighty Bollywood at the box-office and has gone global, attracting plaudits from every savant out there. The success of films like *RRR* makes us all proud. There are many other newsmakers you will find in this issue who made a difference of one kind or another. All of this speaks of India not as a static tradition but as an evolving entity.

Such were the people and the events that contributed to 2022 being an exciting, even if turbulent, year. And then there was the return of the cheetah to India after 70-odd years—all the way from Africa. New beginnings for them, and wishing you all Happy New Beginnings for 2023.



(Aroon Purie)